

Kluckhohn and Strodtbeck's Values Orientation Theory

One theory of basic human values which has been very influential is that of Kluckhohn and Strodtbeck (1961). Florence Kluckhohn and Fred Strodtbeck set out to operationalise a theoretical approach to the values concept developed by Florence's husband, Clyde Kluckhohn. He argued that humans share biological traits and characteristics which form the basis for the development of culture, and that people typically feel their own cultural beliefs and practices are normal and natural, and those of others are strange, or even inferior or abnormal. He defined a value as: "A conception, explicit or implicit, distinctive of an individual or characteristic of a group, of the desirable which influences the selection from available modes, means and ends of action."

Florence Kluckhohn and Fred Strodtbeck developed a theory which put these principles into action. They started with three basic assumptions:

- "There is a limited number of common human problems for which all peoples must at all times find some solution".
- "While there is variability in solutions of all the problems, it is neither limitless nor random but is definitely variable within a range of possible solutions".
- "All alternatives of all solutions are present in all societies at all times but are differentially preferred".

They suggested that the solutions for these problems preferred by a given society reflects that society's values. Consequently, measurement of the preferred solutions would indicate the values espoused by that society. They suggested five basic types of problem to be solved by every society:

- On what aspect of time should we primarily focus – past, present or future?
- What is the relationship between Humanity and its natural environment – mastery, submission or harmony?
- How should individuals relate with others – hierarchically (which they called "Lineal"), as equals ("Collateral"), or according to their individual merit?
- What is the prime motivation for behaviour – to express one's self ("Being"), to grow ("Being-in-becoming"), or to achieve?
- What is the nature of human nature – good, bad ("Evil") or a mixture?

Kluckhohn and Strodtbeck also suggested a sixth value dimension of Space (Here, There, or Far Away) but did not explore it further. They then spelled out the possible answers to each of the questions, arguing that the preferred answer in any society reflects the basic orientation

of the society to that aspect of its environment. The orientations to each question are shown in Table 1.

Table 1.

Four basic questions and the value orientations reflected in their answers.

Question	Orientation	description
time	Past	We focus on the past (the time before now), and on preserving and maintaining traditional teachings and beliefs.
	Present	We focus on the present (what is now), and on accommodating changes in beliefs and traditions.
	Future	We focus on the future (the time to come), planning ahead, and seeking new ways to replace the old.
Humanity and Natural Environment	mastery	We can and should exercise total control over the forces of, and in, nature and the super-natural
	harmonious	We can and should exercise partial but not total control by living in a balance with the natural forces
	submissive	We cannot and should not exercise control over natural forces but, rather, are subject to the higher power of these forces.
Relating to other people	Hierarchical ("Lineal")	Emphasis on hierarchical principles and deferring to higher authority or authorities within the group
	As equals ("Collateral")	Emphasis on consensus within the extended group of equals
	Individualistic	Emphasis on the individual or individual families within the group who make decisions independently from others
Motive for behaving	Being	Our motivation is internal, emphasising activity valued by our self but not necessarily by others in the group
	Being-in-becoming	Motivation is to develop and grow in abilities which are valued by us, although not necessarily by others
	Achievement ("Doing")	Our motivation is external to us, emphasizing activity that is both valued by ourselves and is approved by others in our group.

In proposing orientations to the Nature of Human nature question, Kluckhohn and Strodtbeck suggested that there are two dimensions involved – good, bad or mixed, and that of mutability, or whether we are born the way we are and cannot change, or can learn to change (in either direction). Moreover they suggested that "mixed" may mean either both good and bad, or neutral. Taking all these considerations into account simultaneously gives us the possible orientations shown in Table 2.

Having set out their theory, Kluckhohn and Strodtbeck then proposed a means of measuring the orientations it produced.

Table 2

Orientations possible in answering the question on the Nature of Human Nature.

Question	Orientation	Description
Nature of Human Nature	evil/mutable	Born evil, but can learn to be good. However danger of regression always present.
	evil/immutable	Born evil and incapable of being changed. Therefore requires salvation by an external force.
	mixture/mutable	Has both good and bad traits, but can learn to be either better or worse.
	mixture/immutable	Has both good and bad traits, and their profile cannot be changed
	neutral/mutable	Born neither good nor bad, but can learn both good and bad traits
	neutral/immutable	Born neither good nor bad, and this profile cannot be changed
	good/mutable	Basically good, but subject to corruption
	good/immutable	Basically good, and will always remain so.

To test their theory out, Kluckhohn and Strodtbeck interviewed members of five different cultural groups in the South-West USA. These included itinerant Navaho, Mexican-Americans, Texan homesteaders, Mormon villagers, and Zuni pueblo dwellers. In doing so, however, they did not attempt to develop measures of the Nature of Human Nature orientations, finding them too complex. For the remaining four dimensions, however they were able to develop real-life situations relevant to all five cultural groups, and questions to probe the value orientations used by members of those cultures in dealing with the situations involved. They were then able to draw value profiles of each group, showing the ways in which they differed from each other, and the ways in which they were similar. All of this work was published in their 1961 book, and immediately made a strong impact on cross-cultural psychologists.

Kluckhohn and Strodtbeck themselves suggested that their theory was not complete. Moreover they did not provide measures for all the orientations they did propose. They therefore left ample opportunity for further development of their theory.

More recently we have also looked at other basic questions for which also all societies must provide answers. These answers are limited in number, and all alternatives are known to all societies. However they differ in the ranking they give each alternative. Examples include the allocation of space, the nature of work, the relationship between the genders, and the relationship between individual and state. Listed below are some alternative answers to these questions, and items illustrating how the rankings given to the alternative orientations can be assessed (see Table 3).

A questionnaire using these questions and others like them has been tested in a small pilot study and the results so far are encouraging. However it has yet to be used in a full-scale

study. There are no doubt other great questions for which all societies must find preferred answers. The meaning of life and death, and the nature of the supernatural and humanity's relationship to it, are two which come to mind. This is further illustration of the potential richness of the Kluckhohn and Strodtbeck theory.

Table 3

Proposed further basic values questions and alternative answers to them

Space

Should space belong to individuals, to groups (especially the family) or to everybody?

It is most important that society guarantee

a) The right of each citizen to have a place they can call their own	Individuals
b) Each family a home of their own	Families or groups
c) The public areas and spaces, available to all, but owned by no one	Everybody

Work

What should be the basic motivation for work? To make a contribution to society, to have a sense of personal achievement, or to attain financial security?

When deciding what courses to take, a university student should give top priority to courses which teach:

a) How to make a contribution to society	Contribution
b) Subjects which are exciting or fulfilling	Achievement
c) Subjects which will ensure a good salary after graduating	Financial security

Gender

How should society distribute roles, power and responsibility between the genders?

The right and responsibility to make decisions which affect the whole community should usually be given to

a) Men	Male
b) Women	Female
c) Both men and women equally	Both

The state-individual relationship

Should precedent right and responsibility be accorded the nation or the individual?

When deciding how an important issue like ensuring that its members have the best health possible, it is best if a society ensures that

a) Each person takes full financial responsibility for their own health care with no subsidy from the state.	Individual
b) Free and full health care is provided for all citizens by the government	Nation

c) The individual and the government each pays a reasonable proportion of health care costs	Both
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It has shortcomings, of course. As it deals with values, rather than attitudes, it is general rather than specific, and so can only be used to examine general trends in behaviour, and not used to predict specific behaviours in any one situation. Moreover most behaviour is multiply determined, and so the theory may be termed simplistic, in that it attempts to explain one dimension at a time. Its use of rankings and preferences makes it difficult to analyse statistically. Despite these faults it is a bold and elegant attempt to express something common to all humanity – the values on which so much of society is based, and from which our attitudes, cognition, emotions and behaviours evolve.

References

Hills, M. D. (2002). Kluckhohn and Strodtbeck's Values Orientation Theory. *Online Readings in Psychology and Culture*, 4(4). <https://doi.org/10.9707/2307-0919.1040>

Vocabulary

序号	英语词汇 (词性)	中文释义
1	orientation (n.)	定位, 取向
2	variability (n.)	可变性, 易变性
3	explicit (adj.)	显性的, 明确的
4	implicit (adj.)	隐性的, 含蓄的
5	espouse (v.)	支持, 赞成
6	mastery (n.)	控制, 驾驭
7	submission (n.)	臣服, 顺从
8	lineal (adj.)	线性的, 直系的
9	collateral (adj.)	附属的, 附加的
10	mutability (n.)	可变性, 易变性
11	itinerant (adj.)	流动的; 巡游的
12	homesteader (n.)	(拥有土地的) 定居者
13	pueblo (n.)	普韦布洛村落
14	probe (v.)	探究, 追问
15	precedent (adj.)	先前的; 优先的
16	accord (v.)	给予; 一致, 相符;
17	simplistic (adj.)	过分简化的
18	multiply (adv.)	多倍地

Exercises

Part I Complete the following paragraph with the most suitable words from the box.

values, mastery, orientation, variability, humanity, espouse, collateral

Kluckhohn and Strodtbeck argued that all societies face a limited number of common human problems, and their solutions reflect underlying (1)_____. They proposed that although solutions vary, this (2)_____ is not random but falls within a range of possible alternatives. One important dimension concerns the relationship between humans and nature, including (3)_____ over nature, living in harmony, or submission to it. Another dimension focuses on how individuals relate to others, whether through hierarchical, (4)_____, or individualistic relationships. These preferred orientations help researchers understand the values (5)_____ by different cultures.

Part II True or false

1. Kluckhohn defined values as concepts that influence how people choose actions and goals.
2. According to the theory, all societies have completely different solutions to human problems with no shared patterns.
3. The theory suggests that societies differ in how they prioritize past, present, or future.
4. In the value orientation of human–nature relationships, all societies believe humans should fully control nature.
5. The theory can accurately predict specific individual behavior in every situation.

Part III Translate the following paragraph into English, using the words or expressions given.

Kluckhohn 和 Strodtbeck 认为，所有社会都必须解决一些共同的人类问题，例如时间取向、人类与自然的关系以及人与人之间的关系。不同社会在这些问题上的选择反映了其核心价值观。例如，人类与自然的关系可以表现为三种取向：对自然的控制、与自然的和谐共处，或对自然力量的顺从。有些社会更强调未来导向，注重规划和发展，而另一些社会则更重视传统和过去。此外，在人与人关系方面，有的社会强调等级结构，而有的则更倾向于平等或个人主义。

Part IV Discussion Questions

1. If all societies share the same set of fundamental problems, why do they still develop such different value orientations?
2. Can value orientations (such as time orientation or human–nature relationship) change over time, or are they relatively stable?
3. Given that the theory cannot predict specific behavior, how useful is it for real-world applications such as business or policymaking?